



@UNCVIET

Language & Culture

MISSION STATEMENT

The UNC Vietnamese Language Program

fosters real-world proficiency and humanistic growth, teaching not just what students **can do** in Vietnamese, but who they can **become** through it.

We serve as a vital hub of **connection** and **belonging** for all whose lives touch Vietnam.

DOING

BECOMING

BELONGING



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Program Pillars

DOING

Task-Based & Real-World Proficiency

We equip learners with the communicative tools to navigate authentic situations with confidence. Language is learned by using it—engaging in meaningful tasks, collaborating on real-world projects, and communicating across diverse professional, social, and cultural settings.

In Practice: Task-based learning, authentic media, interactive communication, and functional fluency.

BECOMING

Humanistic Growth & Critical Empathy

Learning Vietnamese is a transformative journey that extends beyond vocabulary and grammar. We cultivate critical thinking, cultural humility, and intercultural agility, helping students reflect on their own worldviews while developing new ways of seeing, listening, and engaging with the world.

In Practice: Intercultural competence, reflective storytelling, critical engagement with history and contemporary culture, and identity exploration.

BELONGING

Community, Diaspora & Connection

Language is a bridge to community. We create an inclusive space that welcomes heritage learners, non-heritage students, the local diaspora, and global partners alike. Our program serves as a home for connection, honor, and mutual learning for anyone whose life touches Vietnam.

In Practice: Heritage language support, community-engaged projects, cultural events, and interdisciplinary collaboration.



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UNC VIETNAMESE AY 2026–2027 Schedule

FALL 2026 (Aug 17 – Dec 11)

VIET 101 section 1 / 9052

Elementary Vietnamese I

10:10–11:00 AM – ***full***

VIET 101 section 2 / 1109

Elementary Vietnamese I

1:25–2:15 PM – **seats available**

VIET 203 section 1 / 9689

Intermediate Vietnamese I

12:20–1:10 PM – ***full, waitlist only***

SPRING 2027 (Jan 6 – May 6)

VIET 102 section 001:

Elementary Vietnamese II

9:05–9:55 AM

VIET 102 section 002

Elementary Vietnamese II

10:10–11:00 AM

VIET 204

Intermediate Vietnamese II

12:20–1:10 PM

VIET 305

Advanced Vietnamese I

1:25–2:15 PM – **First-Ever Offering**

VIET 204 and VIET 305 count toward the Southeast Asian Studies minor

WEEKLY ACTIVITIES

Vietnamese Language Circle

An informal weekly conversation hour open to students, community members, and anyone interested in Vietnamese language and culture—no enrollment required.

Office Hours (Drop-in Café ☕)

Meet with your instructors, ask questions, receive individualized support, and discuss coursework, language learning, or other academic interests.

*** Plus FLTA-led stories, crafts, and cultural activities**

AY PLANNED EVENTS

Fall Events

- Tết Trung Thu (Mid-Autumn Festival)
- Vietnamese Folk Games Day

Spring Events

- Tết Celebration & Gathering
- Vietnamese Culture Connect

VSA PLANNED EVENTS

- Monthly GBMs
- Charity Gala /Nov
- VietNite /April

*** Follow @uncviet and @uncvsa for latest updates**

All six Vietnamese language courses are approved and listed in the catalog. VIET 101–204 are sequential. VIET 305 and VIET 306 are theme-based courses that may be taken in any order or independently. Coming Soon: VIET/ASIA 324 – Vietnamese Foodways: History, Identity & Globalization (scheduling pending). Planned: VIET/ASIA 224 – Vietnamese Pop Culture



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People & Community

PROGRAM TEAM



Dr. Huy Phung

Coordinator of the Vietnamese Language Program and Teaching Assistant Professor in the Dept. of Asian & Middle Eastern Studies (DAMES).



Hiền-Thanh Nguyễn

Fulbright FLTA for 2026–2027, co-teaching this fall and teaching one section of VIET 102 in spring.

PROGRAM ADVISORS



Dr. Becky Butler

Assistant Director for Southeast Asia Initiatives at INSITE: Asia; advises the Southeast Asian Studies Minor. Teaches LING/ASIA 260 and AMST/ASIA 353.



Dr. Christian Lentz

Associate Professor of Geography; scholar of political and territorial history. Teaches GEOG 64 (Vietnam First-Year Seminar) and GEOG 266.

STUDENT & COMMUNITY ORGS



UNC VSA

Our closest student-org partner, co-hosting community events, GBMs, and VietNite. @uncvsa



UNC SEASA

The Southeast Asian Student Association and our regional counterpart to VSA. @uncseasa



Blue Crescent Lion Dance

Performs energetic lion dances at various events. @bluecrescentld



The Vietnamese Circle

Our student-run Vietnamese club, hosting the weekly Language Table and other cultural activities



Blue Haven

Student music ensemble; brings live musical and cultural performances to program gatherings. @uncbluehaven

The UNC Vietnamese Language Program is a hub for everyone whose life touches Vietnam – faculty, students, and community partners across the Triangle and beyond. Follow @uncviet for the latest.



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UNC VIETNAMESE
Voices & Reflections

STUDENT VOICES

"I felt that I was really able to connect to parts of my Vietnamese heritage through language..."

– **VIET 102 student**

"I get a lot of practice... because the class is small, I'm able to foster good relationships."

– **VIET 102 student**

"He opened us to different traditions... and allowed us to come out of our comfort zone..."

– **VIET 102 student**

EVENT REFLECTIONS

"What I appreciated most... is how it brought together students with many different identities... a great example of how language and culture bring people together."

– **Dr. Becky Butler on VCC 2026**

"I expected it to be a social event... I was surprised by the ingenious integration of academic and social together... a model for other programs."

– **Dr. Li-Ling Hsiao, Chair, Dept. of AMES**

Vietnamese Culture Connect
<https://tinyurl.com/vietcc26>



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The question I keep asking is not only what students **can do** in Vietnamese, but also who students can **become** through Vietnamese.

– **DR. HUY PHUNG**, Program Coordinator



LEARN. Enroll in VIET courses and content courses (taught in English).

ATTEND. Join us at Vietnamese Language Circle, Tết Celebrations, Vietnamese Culture Connect, and other cultural events.

SHARE. Follow @uncviet, tag a friend, spread the word.

CONNECT WITH US

Instagram: @uncviet

Discord: UNCVIET server

Linktr.ee: uncviet



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UNC VIETNAMESE
The Mascot: Con Trâu

THE ORIGIN

Our Mascot: Con Trâu

Con trâu – the water buffalo – is the icon of @uncviet. Like Rameses on the same campus, ours is horned, grounded, and unmistakably itself. Diligent, grounded, patient, and communal – the buffalo carries the same qualities as **Doing, Becoming, and Belonging**, the mission this program lives by.

Why the Buffalo?

▲ **The Land:** Since the Hùng Kings, the trâu has plowed Vietnam's rice paddies – the living engine behind Vietnam's wet-rice civilization.



✦ **The Zodiac:** In the Vietnamese zodiac, Sửu (the buffalo) is hardworking, dependable, and calm under pressure – the same qualities it takes to learn a language.



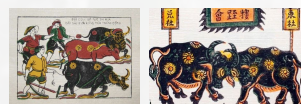
ONE WORD, MANY WORLDS

In Art, Philosophy & Film



🌀 **Đông Hồ Prints:**

Trâu Sen, a child riding a buffalo through a lotus pond, is an iconic Vietnamese image.



🏡 **The Sage:** Laozi rode a *thanh ngưu* (blue ox) toward wisdom; in Zen, the ox is the mind itself.

🎬 **On Screen:** *Mùa Len Trâu* (2004), Vietnam's Oscar submission, follows the water buffalo through Mekong Delta floods.

🌿 **The Craft – Trâu Lá Đa**

Before toy stores, there were leaves. Fold a jackfruit or banyan leaf into a buffalo, thread a blade of grass through the "neck," and pull – the head nods and the buffalo calls out *nghe ọ*. No cost, no instructions – passed down for generations across the Vietnamese countryside.



"Con trâu là đầu cơ nghiệp." – The water buffalo is the foundation of all prosperity. (a well-known Vietnamese proverb). Patient, grounded, and quietly determined: the spirit behind everything we build at @uncviet.